

Summary

Companies offering the same consumer financial products resolve complaints very differently. In 2025, relief rates for checking account complaints ranged from about 4% to 40% among major companies, and two of the largest payment providers resolved almost no complaints in consumers' favor. Complaint volume is also highly sensitive to outside events: a single three-day surge in January, driven by social media activity and enforcement publicity, accounted for over 60,000 complaints against four companies. Compliance teams should benchmark complaint outcomes against peers and monitor volume closely enough to separate coordinated campaigns from genuine consumer harm.

Data and approach

The analysis covers all 5,442,964 complaints the CFPB received in 2025, drawn from its public Consumer Complaint Database archive. Credit reporting accounted for 88% of these, and the three national credit bureaus alone for about 86%, so including them would obscure every other pattern.

I therefore excluded the credit reporting product, the 94,271 complaints against the bureaus filed under other product labels (most likely credit report disputes), and 285 complaints still in progress. The remaining 538,171 complaints cover debt collection, banking, payments, lending, and servicing.

For each company with at least 1,000 complaints, I measured two outcomes companies report to the CFPB: the share of responses that were timely, and the share of complaints closed with monetary or non-monetary relief. Comparisons are made within the same product wherever possible, since relief norms differ across products.

Key findings

1. Debt collection is the largest source of complaints

Debt collection accounts for 39.5% of complaints, followed by money transfers and payment services (15.7%) and checking or savings accounts (15.6%). The single most common issue is attempts to collect debt the consumer says is not owed (115,679 complaints). Several leading issues, including false statements and threatened legal action, correspond to conduct regulated under the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act.

2. Relief rates vary tenfold among companies offering the same product

For checking account complaints, Citibank and Bank of America provided relief about 40% of the time, while Capital One did so in about 4% of cases. Payment providers show a similar split:

Payment provider	Complaints	Relief rate
PayPal	5,482	30%
Coinbase	1,294	26%
Block (Cash App)	42,569	0%
Early Warning Services (Zelle)	19,703	0%

Block's near-zero rate held even after excluding the January surge (0.2% from February onward), so it reflects a persistent pattern rather than a one-time distortion. Zelle is a partial exception, since consumers' own banks often handle disputes on its network.

3. A three-day surge in January distorted company metrics

Complaints against Zelle, Block, Navy Federal, and Capital One were at normal levels until January 14, 2025, then exploded within three days. Zelle received 81% of its annual complaints in January, and Block 65%.

The causes differed. Reporting by Consumer Reports attributes most of the Zelle and Cash App surge to a viral social media campaign that falsely promised settlement payments to anyone who filed a complaint. The Navy Federal and Capital One spikes coincided with CFPB enforcement actions announced that month.

The surge materially changed company-level results. Navy Federal provided relief in about 4% of its January complaints but 30% of complaints afterward, so its full-year rate understates its typical complaint handling.

4. Complaint volume rose through the second half of 2025

Monthly complaints held near 35,000 from February to June, then climbed steadily to 52,587 in December, about 50% higher. The increase was broad, affecting banks, debt collectors, and fintechs alike.

Recommendations

1. **Benchmark complaint outcomes against peers.** Compliance teams should compare their relief rates with companies offering the same product. A rate far below peers is a signal to review how complaints are investigated and resolved.
2. **Review dispute handling at low-relief payment providers.** Providers resolving almost no complaints should test whether their processes for unauthorized transactions meet Electronic Fund Transfer Act requirements, an area the CFPB cited in its January 2025 order against Block.
3. **Monitor complaint volume daily and screen for templated submissions.** Daily monitoring would have flagged the January surge within a day. Comparing narrative text can help separate coordinated campaigns from genuine harm, so real problems are not dismissed and campaign-driven noise does not distort metrics.
4. **Standardize complaint outcome definitions.** Because companies self-report outcomes, one company's "closed with explanation" may be another's "non-monetary relief." Regulators should define outcome categories precisely so cross-company comparisons are reliable.

Limitations

Complaint outcomes are reported by companies and not verified by the CFPB, and complaints are not a representative sample of consumer experiences. Complaints about depository institutions with less than \$10 billion in assets are not published in the database. Raw complaint counts are not adjusted for company size, which is why this analysis focuses on outcome rates. Finally, low relief rates indicate areas for investigation, not proof of misconduct, since some complaints may lack a valid claim.

Links and sources

- Interactive dashboard: [add your Tableau Public link]
- Analysis notebook: [add your GitHub link]
- Data: [CFPB Consumer Complaint Database archive](#)
- [CFPB enforcement action against Block, Inc.](#)
- [CFPB lawsuit against Early Warning Services and three banks](#)
- [CFPB lawsuit against Capital One \(Bankrate\)](#)
- [Consumer Reports on the social media complaint campaign](#)
- [Consumer Federation of America on Navy Federal overdraft complaints](#)